TRADITIONAL AND NEW DIPLOMACY

Till the end of eighteenth century, diplomacy was branded as old or traditional diplomacy. The nineteenth century diplomacy is referred to as *modern diplomacy* which involved newer methods and personnel because of change in the very nature of diplomacy.

An academic interpretation of old European kind of diplomacy has been provided by Kenneth W.Thompson (American academic and author in the field of international relations). He described the background of diplomacy in the following terms: “In theory at least, it sought to mitigate and reduce conflicts by means of persuasion, compromise and adjustment. It was a diplomacy rooted in the community of interests of a small group of leaders who spoke the same language, catered as often to one another as their own people, and played to one another’s strengths and weaknesses. When warfare broke out, they drew a ring around combatants and sought to localize and neutralize the struggle. The old diplomacy… carried out its tasks in a world made up of states that were small, separated, limited in power and blessed ironically enough, by half-hearted political loyalties. Patience was a watchword; negotiations and talks would be initiated, broken off, resumed, discontinued temporarily and reopened again by professionals in whose lexicon there was no substitute for diplomacy”.

There were certain factors which brought about changes in the theory and practice of diplomacy and ushered in a new era of diplomacy. Nicolson speaks of “Old Diplomacy” and its disreputable variant “Secret Diplomacy” which, he points out, saw a great white light in the year 1918 and gradually moved on to its new form of new diplomacy. Seventeenth or eighteenth century diplomacy now stood in sharp contrast with its modern form—the nineteenth century diplomacy. Nicolson[21] however, contends that no sudden conversion has taken place, neither sharp contrasts of principle or method could be recognized; only what has happened was that the art of negotiation has gradually adjusted itself to changes in the political conditions. Nicolson has called attention to these developments as: